ERA 7

The Market Revolution

1815 – 1850

Technology · transportation · immigration · a changing society

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did new technology, transportation, and immigration transform American society and economy?

KEY TERMS

Market Revolution · Lowell System · Erie Canal · interchangeable parts · nativism · cult of domesticity

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 4.5–4.6 · AMSCO Ch. 4.5–4.6

FROM FARM TO FACTORY

The Market Revolution

The Factory System



- **Samuel Slater** built America's first factory in 1790.
- **Francis Cabot Lowell** pioneered large mills that spun and wove under one roof.
- By the 1820s New England was the nation's manufacturing center.

Inventions Transform Work

I

Interchangeable Parts

Eli Whitney (1801) enabled mass production of identical parts.

II

The Telegraph

Samuel Morse let messages cross the country in seconds.

III

The Sewing Machine

New machines sped up manufacturing and everyday life.

The Cotton Gin's Double Edge

- **Eli Whitney**'s 1793 **cotton gin** fed the booming Northern textile mills.
- It made cotton the nation's leading export.
- But it also made slavery vastly more profitable—and entrenched in the South.



SECTION

The Transportation Revolution

Connecting a Continent

1807

Steamboat

Fulton's Clermont proves steam travel upriver.

1825

Erie Canal

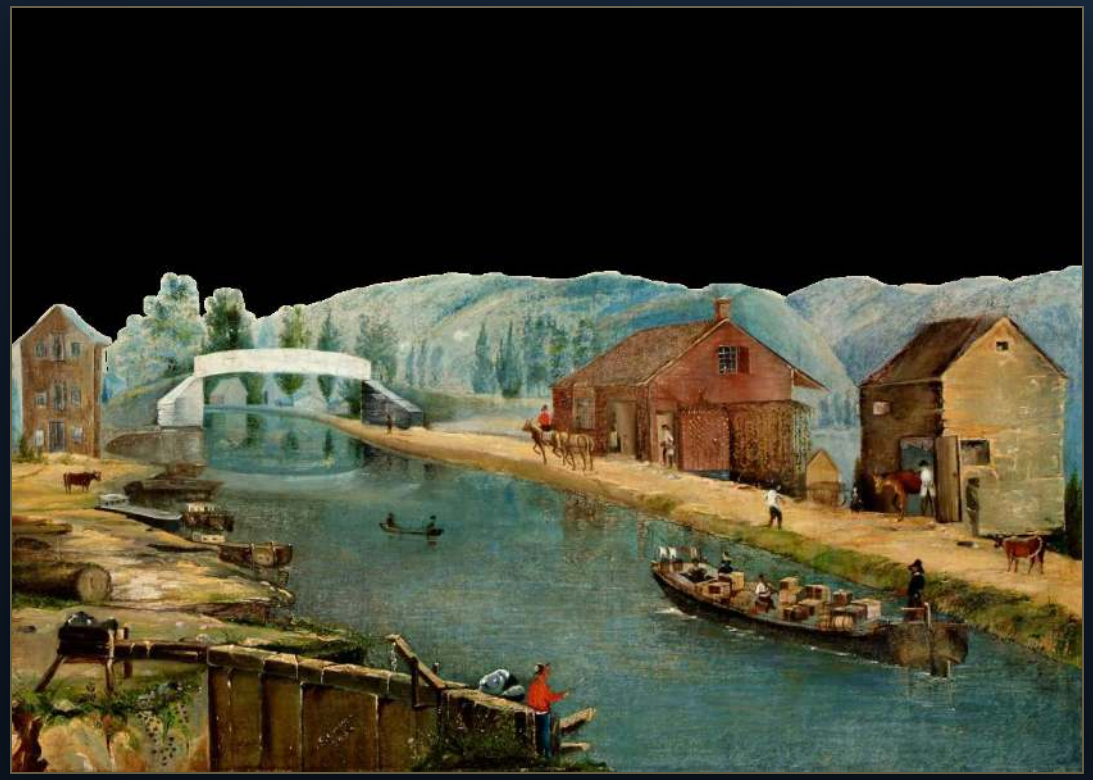
A canal boom links the interior to the coast.

1830s+

Railroads

Rail rapidly overtakes canals across the North.

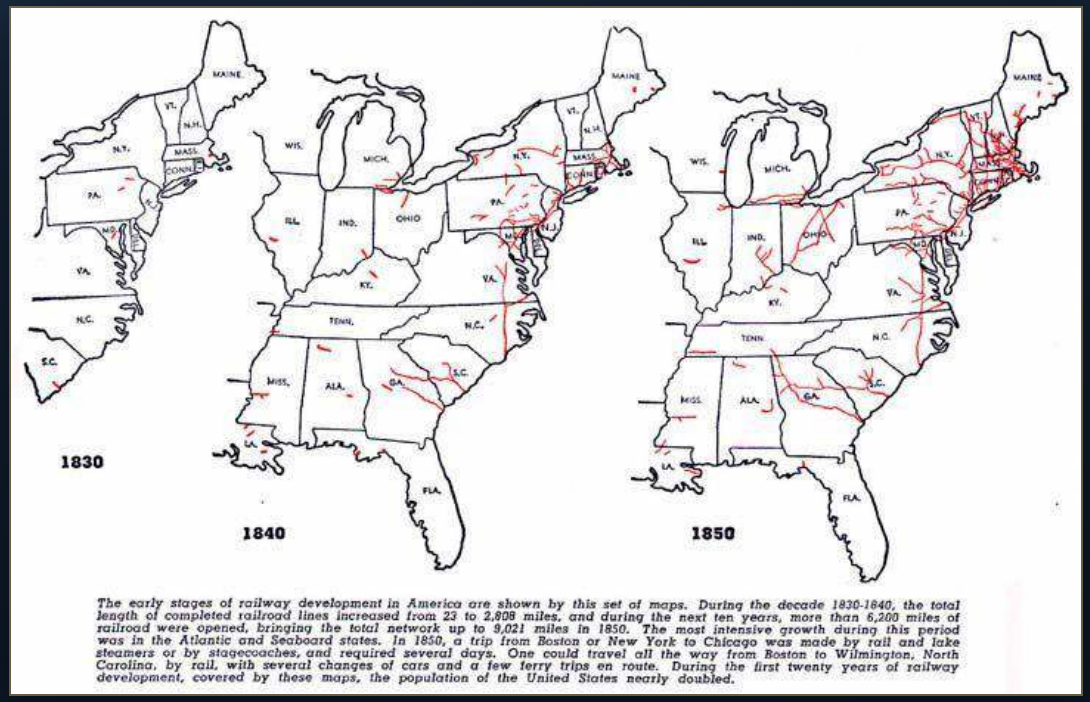
The Erie Canal, 1825



- The **Erie Canal** linked the Great Lakes to New York City.
- It slashed shipping costs and sparked a nationwide canal boom.
- It made New York City the nation's commercial capital.

The Age of Railroads

- **Railroads** soon supplanted **canals** as the fastest movers of goods.
- Track grew from under 3,000 miles in 1840 to over 27,000 by 1860.
- Rail tied the North and West into a single market.



The early stages of railway development in America are shown by this set of maps. During the decade 1830-1840, the total length of completed railroad lines increased from 23 to 2,808 miles, and during the next ten years, more than 6,200 miles of railroad were opened, bringing the total network up to 9,021 miles in 1850. The most intensive growth during this period was in the Atlantic and Seaboard states. In 1850, a trip from Boston or New York to Chicago was made by rail and lake steamers or by stagecoaches, and required several days. One could travel all the way from Boston to Wilmington, North Carolina, by rail, with several changes of cars and a few ferry trips en route. During the first twenty years of railway development, covered by these maps, the population of the United States nearly doubled.

SECTION

A Nation of Immigrants

The Immigration Boom



- Between 1840 and 1860, millions of Europeans arrived.
- The **Irish**—fleeing the **Potato Famine**—crowded eastern cities.
- **Germans** often had means and pushed into the Midwest.

Nativism & the Know-Nothings

- The immigrant surge fueled **nativism**—fear and hatred of newcomers.
- Because most **Irish** and Germans were Catholic, anti-Catholic feeling grew.
- It gave rise to the nativist **Know-Nothing** Party.



SECTION

A Changing Society

Cities & a New Middle Class



- Factories and trade fueled rapid **urban** growth.
- A new **middle class** of managers and professionals emerged.
- **Tocqueville** marveled at America's 'equality of condition.'

Women & the Lowell System



- The **Lowell System** hired young women to work its mills.
- They lived in supervised boardinghouses and sent wages home.
- Women were ~85% of the workforce—but 0% of management.

The Cult of Domesticity

I

Separate Spheres

As men worked outside the home, home became a 'woman's sphere.'

II

The Ideal Woman

Middle-class women were expected to nurture the family and morality.

III

A Narrowing Role

The ideal limited many women to the domestic world.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Market Revolution

1. **New technology** (**interchangeable parts**, the **telegraph**) and **transportation** (the **Erie Canal**, **railroads**) knit together a national market economy.

2. A wave of **Irish and German immigration** transformed cities—and sparked a **nativist** backlash.

3. Industrialization created a **middle class**, drew women into factories, and hardened the **cult of domesticity** at home.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Market Revolution

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **transportation improvements** (canals, railroads) reshaped the American economy.

COMPARISON

Compare how the Market Revolution affected **Northern factory workers** and **Southern enslaved laborers**.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did industrialization change the **roles of women**—both in the factory and in the home?

Up next — **Class 20: An Age of Reform** (the Second Great Awakening, abolition & women's rights)